FREE RESOURCE

The Founder *Sales & Systems* Checklist

Find out what's actually stopping your business from growing.

OFFER CLARITY | VISIBILITY | LEAD CAPTURE | SALES | SYSTEMS | PARTNERSHIPS | COMMUNITY

TOTAL SCORE

/ 35

7 sections · 4 questions each

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INTRODUCTION

Most businesses are stuck because of one or two bottlenecks.

Most founders do not need another idea. They do not need more motivation, more content to consume, or another course to buy. What they need is clarity on what is actually broken inside their business right now.

> This checklist was built for one purpose: to help you quickly identify the one or two areas that are quietly limiting your growth — so you can stop guessing and start fixing.

It covers seven core areas of a functioning business: your offer, your visibility, how you capture leads, how you sell, your systems, your partnerships, and your community. Each section is scored out of five. Your total score out of 35 will tell you exactly where to focus your energy.

Be honest with yourself as you go through it. The more accurate your answers, the more useful this becomes.

HOW TO USE THIS CHECKLIST

1. Read each question and check the box if the answer is honestly yes.
2. Count your checkmarks per section and record your score (0–5).
3. Add up all seven sections for your total score out of 35.
4. Use the score guide and reflection prompts to build your 30-day plan.

01 OFFER CLARITY

Offer Clarity

If people do not immediately understand what you sell and why it matters, they will not buy it — no matter how good it actually is.

- [ ] **Someone can explain what you sell in one clear sentence.**
  Ask a friend or family member to describe your business. If they struggle, your messaging needs work.
- [ ] **Customers understand the value of your offer quickly — without a long explanation.**
  A strong offer communicates its value within the first 10 seconds of exposure.
- [ ] **You serve a specific, well-defined audience — not everyone.**
  Trying to serve everyone is the fastest way to connect with no one.
- [ ] **People know why they should choose you over the alternatives.**
  Your unique selling point is clear, specific, and believable — not just "great service."

SECTION SCORE 0 1 2 3 4 5 *Circle your score*

02 VISIBILITY

Visibility

A great offer that nobody sees is the same as no offer at all. Visibility is not about going viral — it is about showing up consistently where your customers already are.

- [ ] **You are consistently showing up online — at least 3 times per week.**
  Consistency builds trust. Sporadic posting builds nothing.
- [ ] **New people regularly discover your business without you personally reaching out to them.**
  This means your content, SEO, referrals, or partnerships are doing some of the work for you.
- [ ] **People can easily find you when they search for what you do.**
  Google your business category and your name. Are you showing up?
- [ ] **You create content that educates, attracts, or builds trust with your target audience.**
  Content does not have to be daily. It has to be intentional and relevant to the people you want to reach.

SECTION SCORE 0 1 2 3 4 5 *Circle your score*

03 LEAD CAPTURE

Lead Capture

Visibility without a system to capture interest is just entertainment. You need a way to collect and follow up with people who show interest in what you do.

- [ ] You have a clear way for interested people to raise their hand — a form, a link, a DM prompt, or a landing page.
  If someone is interested right now, do they know exactly what to do next?
- [ ] You are actively building an email list or a direct contact database.
  Social media followers are rented. An email list is owned. Own your audience.
- [ ] You offer something valuable in exchange for someone's contact information.
  A checklist, a guide, a free call, a discount — something that makes giving you their email worth it.
- [ ] You follow up with new leads within 24–48 hours of them showing interest.
  Speed to follow-up is one of the highest-leverage moves in early-stage sales.

SECTION SCORE 0 1 2 3 4 5 *Circle your score*

04 SALES

Sales

Revenue is the lifeblood of your business. Selling is not a dirty word — it is the act of helping the right person solve a real problem. If you are not selling confidently, the business stalls.

- [ ] **You have a repeatable process for converting interested leads into paying customers.**
  Not just "I talk to people." A defined sequence: discovery → proposal → close → onboard.

- [ ] **You are comfortable talking about your price without discounting or apologizing.**
  Price confidence is a signal of value confidence. If you hesitate, buyers hesitate.

- [ ] **You know your conversion rate — what percentage of conversations turn into sales.**
  You cannot improve what you do not measure. Even a rough estimate is better than nothing.

- [ ] **You proactively ask for referrals and introductions from happy customers.**
  The easiest sale you will ever make is to someone who was referred by someone who trusts you.

SECTION SCORE 0 1 2 3 4 5 *Circle your score*

05 SYSTEMS

Systems

A business that runs only when you are personally running it is not a business — it is a job. Systems free your time, reduce errors, and make growth possible without burning out.

- [ ] **Your core business processes are documented — someone else could follow them.**
  Onboarding, delivery, invoicing, follow-up. If it only lives in your head, it is a risk.
- [ ] **You use tools to automate repetitive tasks — scheduling, invoicing, reminders, or follow-ups.**
  Every hour you spend on admin is an hour you are not spending on growth or delivery.
- [ ] **You track your key numbers weekly — revenue, leads, expenses, and conversion.**
  You do not need a complex dashboard. A simple spreadsheet reviewed weekly is enough.
- [ ] **Your business could operate for one week without you being available every day.**
  This is the real test of whether you have a business or a dependency.

SECTION SCORE 0 1 2 3 4 5 *Circle your score*

06 PARTNERSHIPS

Partnerships

The fastest path to growth is rarely a solo one. Strategic partnerships and referral relationships can multiply your reach without multiplying your workload.

- [ ] **You have at least two or three people who actively refer business to you on a regular basis.**
  Referral partners are not accidents. They are built through intentional relationship investment.
- [ ] **You have identified complementary businesses that serve your same audience without competing with you.**
  These are your best partnership targets. They already have the trust of the people you want to reach.
- [ ] **You have a clear, easy way for partners to refer people to you — a link, a one-pager, or a simple script.**
  Make it effortless for people to send you business. Friction kills referrals.
- [ ] **You have appeared in front of someone else's audience in the last 90 days — a podcast, an event, a collaboration, or a guest post.**
  Borrowed audiences are one of the fastest ways to grow your own.

SECTION SCORE 0 1 2 3 4 5 *Circle your score*

07 COMMUNITY

Community

Founders who build in isolation move slower and burn out faster. The right community provides accountability, perspective, introductions, and the honest feedback that friends and family cannot give you.

- [ ] **You are part of at least one community of other founders or business owners who challenge and support you.**
  Not a Facebook group you never open. An active community where real conversations happen.

- [ ] **You have at least one person you can call when you are stuck, overwhelmed, or need a second opinion.**
  This is not a coach or a mentor necessarily — it is just someone who gets it.

- [ ] **You regularly attend events, meetups, or calls where you are around other ambitious people.**
  Your environment shapes your standards. Who you are around determines what feels normal.

- [ ] **You contribute to your community — you give, share, and show up — not just consume.**
  The founders who get the most from communities are the ones who give the most to them.

SECTION SCORE 0 1 2 3 4 5 *Circle your score*

YOUR RESULTS

What your score means.

ADD UP YOUR SECTION SCORES

____ / 35

7 sections · max 5 per section

0–14
LOW

Foundation First

Your business has significant gaps in the fundamentals. The good news: this is the most fixable stage. You do not need more tactics — you need to build the foundation correctly. Focus on offer clarity and lead capture before anything else.

→ Focus on Sections 01 and 03 first.

15–21
BUILDING

Building Momentum

You have some things working but the business is inconsistent. You likely have a clear offer but are missing the systems or visibility to make it repeatable. Pick the two lowest-scoring sections and fix them this month.

→ Identify your two lowest sections and focus there.

22–28
GROWING

Growing with Gaps

You have a functioning business with real traction. The gaps at this stage are usually in systems, partnerships, or community — the things that allow you to scale without burning out. This is the right time to invest in structure.

→ Focus on Sections 05 and 06 to unlock the next level.

29–35
STRONG

Strong Foundation

You have built something real. The opportunity now is to go deeper — refine your systems, strengthen your partnerships, and invest in the community and environment that will carry you to the next level of growth.

→ You are ready for a serious founder room. Apply to EFC.

COMMON PATTERNS

The 5 most common founder bottlenecks.

🎯 The Unclear Offer

The founder knows what they do, but the market does not. The offer is too broad, too vague, or too focused on features rather than outcomes. The fix is not a rebrand — it is a single, specific sentence that a stranger can repeat back to you.

📣 The Invisible Business

The product is good but nobody knows it exists. The founder is waiting to be discovered instead of showing up. Visibility is not about talent — it is about consistency. Three intentional touchpoints per week, over six months, will change your business.

🔁 The Broken Follow-Up

Leads come in and disappear. There is no system to capture, nurture, or convert them. Most sales are lost not because the prospect said no — but because the founder never followed up a second or third time. A simple CRM and a 3-email sequence fixes 80% of this.

⚙️ The Founder Bottleneck

Everything runs through the founder. Every decision, every delivery, every client interaction. This is not a business — it is a self-employment trap. The exit is documentation and delegation, even if the first hire is a $15/hour virtual assistant.

🤝 The Solo Builder

The founder is building in isolation — no peer group, no accountability, no one to challenge their thinking. This leads to slow decisions, repeated mistakes, and eventual burnout. The right room of people is not a luxury. It is infrastructure.

REFLECTION

Founder reflection.

Use these prompts to turn your score into a clear, honest plan. Write your answers below — or in a notebook if you need more space.

1. What is the single biggest thing holding your business back right now?

2. Which section had your lowest score — and what is one specific action you could take this week to improve it?

3. If your business was operating at a 30/35 score 90 days from now, what would be different?

YOUR NEXT MOVE

The simple founder growth plan.

You do not need a 47-step strategy. You need five things done consistently. Here they are.

01 Nail your one-sentence offer

Write a single sentence that describes who you help, what you help them do, and what the outcome is. Test it on five people who do not know your business. If they cannot repeat it back, rewrite it.

WEEK 1

02 Show up three times per week — no exceptions

Pick one platform where your customers already are. Post three times per week for 60 days. Educate, share, or inspire. Do not sell every time. Build trust first.

WEEKS 1–8

03 Build a simple lead capture system

Create one free resource worth having. Put it behind a simple form. Drive traffic to it from your content. Follow up with every new lead within 48 hours. That is the whole system.

WEEK 2

04 Document your top three processes

Pick the three things you do most often in your business. Write down the steps. Put them somewhere you can find them. This is the beginning of a business that does not require you to be present for everything.

WEEK 3

05 Get into the right room

Find one community, one mastermind, or one peer group of founders who are operating at or above your level. Show up consistently. Contribute generously. The relationships you build there will be worth more than any tactic in this checklist.

THIS MONTH

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

About Oge.

Oge Madu

FOUNDER & COMMUNITY BUILDER · EARLY FOUNDERS COLLECTIVE

Oge Madu is a serial entrepreneur and community builder who has founded and scaled multiple businesses across service, media, and technology. He created the Early Founders Collective to give early-stage founders the one thing that is hardest to find on your own: a serious room of peers who will tell you the truth, make introductions that matter, and hold you accountable to the business you said you were going to build.

His work is grounded in a simple belief: the right environment changes everything. Most founders are not failing because they lack information. They are failing because they are building alone, in the wrong room, or without the systems that turn effort into results.

This checklist is the first step. The room is the next one.

VENTURES & PROJECTS

Paint HTX	SoleTies Run Club	Phēnyx
Jolie Cocktail Lounge	The Blackseed Group	Early Founders Collective

You have done the work. Now get in the room.

Stop building *alone.*

The Early Founders Collective is a curated community for serious early-stage founders. Real conversations. Honest feedback. Introductions that matter. Accountability that sticks.

If your score showed you where the gaps are, the Collective is where you close them — surrounded by founders who are doing the same work.

APPLY NOW

earlyfounderscollective.com

COMMUNITY	FORMAT	ACCESS	FOCUS
Peer Founders	**Curated Room**	**Application Only**	**Execution**